occasion for celebration, but a cause for reflection'. Why, after all, did the police and concerned security agencies, and large sections of the 'independent' media have to go to such lengths to frame a man against whom they could not provide a shred of quality evidence in the special POTA court, in the high court, and in the Supreme Court? Now that at least two of the accused can walk free, and one other can live (albeit in prison), we need to begin to ask what really happened. Some others may have to do whatever is necessary and permissible under the law to ensure that Shaukat Husain too is able to leave prison sooner and that Mohammad Afzal does not take the final walk to the gallows.

The doubts about the circumstances that led to the attack on the Indian Parliament will persist as long as the primary actors in the case do not reveal, or are not compelled to reveal, through the process of an independent and impartial inquiry, the roles that they have played. A committee to demand precisely such an enquiry has indeed been constituted by a group of citizens, but as of now, no agency of the state, or civil society, and no voices of substance in the media have either endorsed or echoed their demand.

If Mohammad Afzal is indeed executed, then some of the truths that he alone (barring some of his handlers and interrogators) has access to, will follow him to his grave. In the event that the spin doctors of the media continue to play the role that they have played so honourably in the duration of this entire set of trials, it is unlikely that anything approximating the truth will ever be made available to the public in India, or indeed, anywhere in the world. The gentlemen and women of the fourth estate, the shining knights of the free press and electronic media of India will once again have demonstrated their willingness to construct an elaborate machine made out of smoke and mirrors that does more to conceal than to reveal. For an alternative version of the events to eventually emerge, it is crucial that Mohammad Afzal's death sentence be challenged, and that S.A.R. Geelani (on whose life there have been two extra-judicial attempts, once while he was in prison, and again outside his advocate Nandita Haksar's residence by an as yet unidentified assailant in February 2005) survives. Both Geelani and Afzal need to live if we are to get any closer to the truth of what happened on 13 December 2001, and why Geelani was framed. It is vital to understand that the 'climate of suspicion' that has led to Afzal's conviction, and to the Supreme Court's unwarranted remark that a 'needle of suspicion' still points at Geelani, are a product of more than four years of consistent information